and Kamath were intensely tutored by their staff and had practised on the machines for days on end for this impending test before the prime minister.

But, of course, Murphy's Law[1] came into full play. The machines refused to respond notwithstanding the villagers' hands having being sanitized clean before this demonstration. As his face and hands started sweating, Bhat even blurted out light-heartedly that performing before the prime minister was making him nervous. Only after much huffing and puffing did the machines oblige and save our collective reputation. The prime minister, of course, was very pleased and asked some very searching questions about financial inclusion before we all trooped out triumphantly.

The Value of Getting Your Hands Dirty

Consider the following sample of questions. Can a bank branch operate out of a village panchayat office? How popular or useful is the kisan credit card? How do poor people with irregular incomes and lumpy expenditures manage their finances? Is the interest rate charged by microfinance institutions usurious? If yes, why are people still borrowing from them? If we make borrowing against the pledge of gold more difficult, who gains and who loses? What do schoolchildren learn about finance? Is that learning effective? Is it the case that villages end up with only soiled currency? How big a grievance is that? Why and how are poor people lured by Ponzi schemes?

These are just a sample of hundreds of questions over which the Reserve Bank could take a more informed view by looking at things from the trenches, as it were. Simply put, the outreach gave a real-life context and a human face to Reserve Bank decision-making.

Personally, I had a lot of fun going on outreach visits to villages. I was always touched by the warmth and affection of the villagers. In Lalpur Karauta village of Uttar Pradesh, I went into a house with a newly built toilet and asked the woman of the house how she felt. *'Meri izzat vaapas aa gayi'*—'I have regained my honour'—was what she told me. I visited the primary school in Jalanga, a village near Bhadrak in Odisha, and chatted